

Step two is to assess whether your idea has the potential to be transformed into a viable business. This phase is marked by resourcefulness as founders seek initial funding, build prototypes and validate their concepts. It's a time of uncertainty, when the idea's strength and the team's resilience becomes paramount. This is the phase where you may face major challenges and may even have to rethink your idea several times. The greatest lesson in this phase is to keep course-correcting yourself unless you are absolutely confident about the path you're on.

THE GO-TO-MARKET CHALLENGE

As an entrepreneur and investor, I go through multiple pitch decks weekly. Most of them have the idea and the product, but many fall short on their go-to-market (GTM) strategy. To bring in your first 100 or 1,000 consumers, a start-up needs to have a GTM strategy that

is simple and clear. If you successfully tackle this challenge, the road ahead becomes pretty smooth.

During our initial days, Varun and I ensured that we had a clear, workable launch strategy. We decided to launch through Amazon, and only after we witnessed some traction on the brand did we create the Mamaearth website. The key lesson here is to keep your GTM strategy as uncomplicated as possible. Entrepreneurs must ensure that their focus at this stage is to define the customer profile, figure out how to reach them, and build a strong word-of-mouth trend through the initial customers, using great products and after-sales service.

BUILDING CAPACITY WITH FUNDING

As the seedling of an idea takes root, early funding rounds provide the nourishment needed for sustained growth. Angel investors and venture capitalists become vital partners, injecting capital in your

project to fuel product development, market expansion and team building. Start-ups need to pivot based on learning from successes and setbacks, all the while striving to achieve product-market fit and scalability.

We started with a goal to build a toxin-free brand for babies, but we soon realised that there was demand for toxin-free personal care products even from older customers. We then diversified our portfolio, and widened our offerings to cater to a higher consumer cohort. This expansion needed securing initial funds to scale operations, onboarding strategic partnerships, and hence, scaling became an imperative. After that, the focus shifted to market dominance and fortifying our position. Each round brought with it a unique set of challenges and learnings, shaping the company's trajectory and my growth as a leader. The goal of each funding infusion should be clearly defined, with one of them being the necessity to bring in a funding partner who can provide strategic support towards achieving the goal.

THE BIG LEAP

We strongly feel that one should never start a business with the goal of creating a company that will be listed on the stock exchange. Getting listed on the exchanges is a significant milestone in a very long journey of a company. The goal should be to create a company with a strong value system that delivers great quality products. The focus for any entrepreneur should be on building a sustainable, and profitable business that delivers on the promises made to the investors and shareholders. At the end of the day, that's the ultimate goal for any company and founder. **BT**

Views are personal



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